

外研社杯·国才杯·2017 年阅读大赛决赛

Questions 1-3 (Suggested completion time: 3 minutes)

Directions: Read the following descriptions. Match the descriptions with the people. Please note there are four extra options you do not need.

A. Mark Twain	1. He was generally considered the greatest English novelist of the Victorian era. A moralist, satirist, and social reformer, he crafted complex plots and striking characters that capture the panorama of English society. The range, compassion, and intelligence of his apprehension of his society and its shortcomings enriched his novels and made him both one of the great forces in 19th-century literature and an influential spokesman of the conscience of his age.
B. Jack London	
C. Thomas Hardy	
D. Charles Dickens	2. He was born in 1770 and was one of the most influential of England’ s Romantic poets. As a young man, he developed a love of nature, a theme reflected in many of his poems. While studying at Cambridge University, he spent a summer holiday on a walking tour in Switzerland and France, and became an enthusiast for the ideals of the French Revolution. He began to write poems when he was at school, but none were published until 1793.
E. William Butler Yeats	
F. William Wordsworth	3. He is regarded as a premier writer of late 19th century America. A humorist, journalist, lecturer, and novelist, he acquired international fame for his travel narratives and for his adventure stories of boyhood. A gifted raconteur, distinctive humorist, and irascible moralist, he transcended the apparent limitations of his origins to become a popular public figure and one of America’ s best and most beloved writers.
G. Ernest Hemingway	

Question 4 (Suggested completion time: 2 minutes)

Directions: Read the text and answer the question according to the text.

Squeeze half a lemon into a bowl and add in a few drops of water. Dip a cotton swab into the mixture, and then use it like a pencil to write a message on a piece of paper. Let the liquid dry ... and disappear. Hold the paper next to (but not touching) a light. Do you notice anything reappearing?

4. Where is the text most probably taken from?

- A) A science textbook.
- B) A cooking magazine.
- C) A game manual.
- D) A puzzle book.

Question 5 (Suggested completion time: 2 minutes)

Directions: *Read the text and answer the question according to the text.*

Lavender's fragrance comes from the essential oils held in the flowers. Newly opened lavender flowers have the best fragrance, so pick the stalks in July. To preserve the flowers, tie bundles with twine and hang somewhere dry and out of strong sunlight to protect the color of the petals.

5. What is the main purpose of this text?

- A) To describe how to harvest lavender plants.
- B) To explain why lavender's fragrance could last a long time.
- C) To indicate the best way to preserve lavender.
- D) To demonstrate how to get the best fragrance of lavender.

Question 6 (Suggested completion time: 2 minutes)

Directions: Read the text and answer the question according to the text.

It's best to set up your PC somewhere that has a Wi-Fi network or other connection to the Internet. Your PC will use that connection to complete certain setup steps. If the network requires a password, have the password ready.

6. What is the most probable type of the text?

- A) A maintenance advice. B) An installing instruction. C) An Internet application. D) A security certificate.

Question 7 (Suggested completion time: 2 minutes)

Directions: Read the text and answer the question according to the text.

When you are convinced that your cause is right, have the courage to take a stand. If you see a problem or an injustice, recognize that no one will fix it but you. As you go forward today, use your minds and hands and your hearts to build something bigger than yourselves. Always remember there is no idea bigger than this. As Dr. Martin Luther King said, "All life is **XXXX**. We are all bound together into a single garment of destiny." If you keep that idea at the forefront of all that you do, if you choose to live your lives at that intersection between technology and the people it serves, if you strive to create the best, give the best, do the best for everyone, not just for some, then today all of humanity has good cause for hope.

7. Which of the following words could most probably be the **XXXX** in the text?

- A) indistinguishable B) integrative C) independent D) interrelated

Question 8 (Suggested completion time: 2 minutes)

Directions: *Read the text and answer the question according to the text.*

I want you to know that we greatly appreciate your dedicated service during these past few years and harbor no ill feelings at all about Home Supplies. Our business was recently purchased by a larger contracting firm and we will be getting our supplies through that firm' s vendors. I attempted to keep the relationship with Home Supplies, but it was not possible.

8. What is the writer' s purpose?

- A) To state that the writer' s company has terminated the business with Home Supplies.
- B) To express the sincere appreciation for Home Supplies' service.
- C) To show the efforts in maintaining the friendship with Home Supplies.
- D) To explain that the company went bankrupt and was sold to a larger company.
- E) To state that the writer' s company has terminated the business with Home Supplies.

Question 9 (Suggested completion time: 2 minutes)

Directions: *Read the text and answer the question according to the text.*

Permanent happiness is fleeting no matter what your bank account looks like, but research shows that money does, in fact, give you short-term bursts of joy—if you spend wisely. Experiences such as concerts or holidays have been shown to bring greater happiness than purchasing stuff. People who spend money on others are also measurably happier than those who treat themselves. So _____.

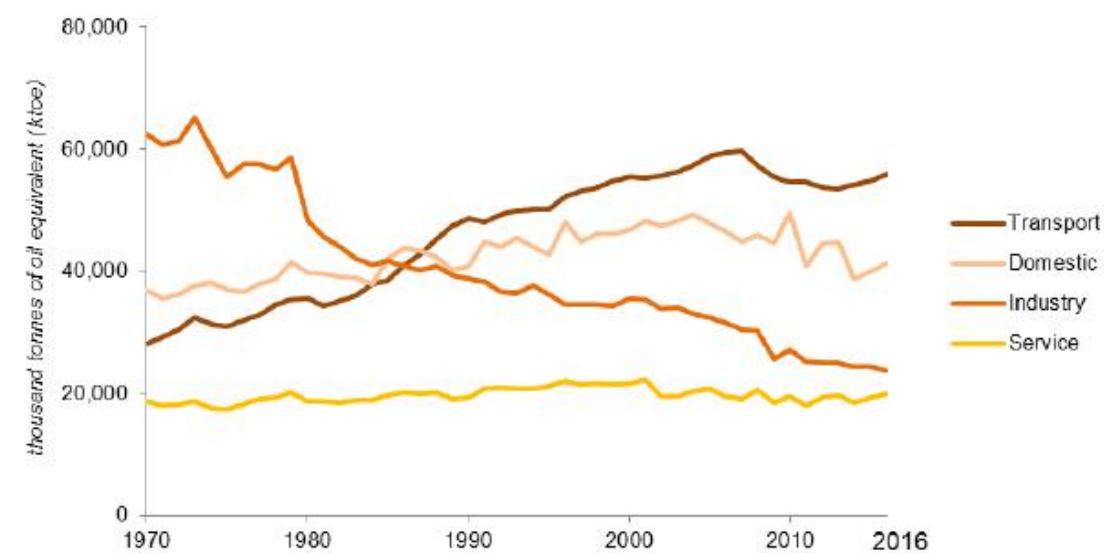
9. Which of the following best fits in the blank in the text?

- A) try to remember: money cannot buy everything C) keep reminding yourself what is real happiness in life
- B) be happy to learn how to manage your money wisely D) do yourself a favor: buy happiness for someone else

Question 10 (Suggested completion time: 5 minutes)

Directions: *The following charts provide an overview of the trends and some key driving forces that have influenced energy consumption in the UK since 1970. Answer the question according to the charts.*

Chart 1 Final energy consumption by sector

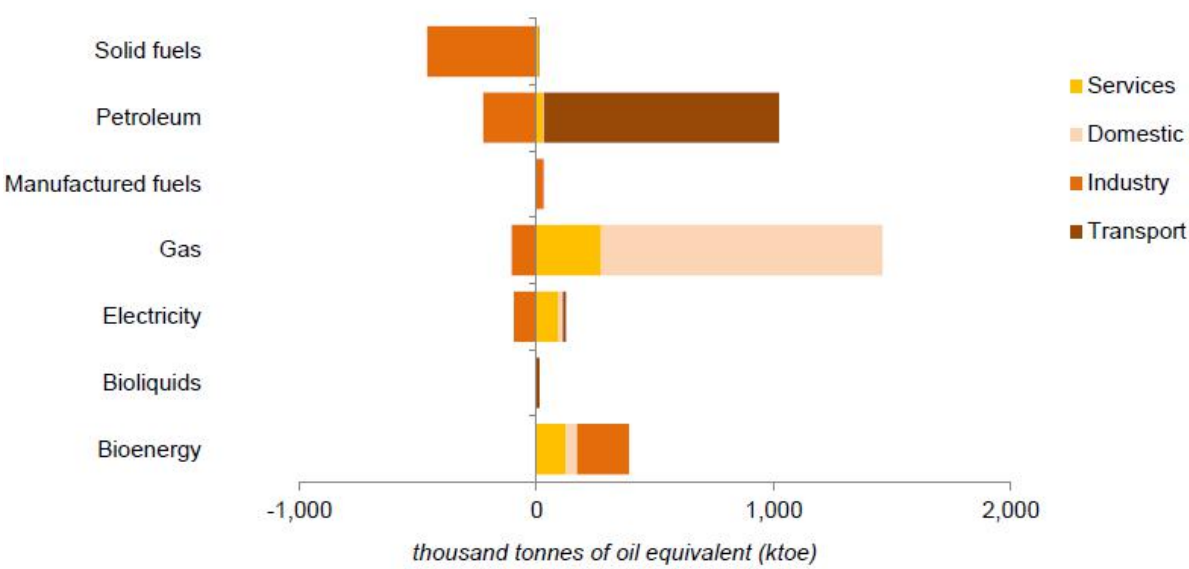


Notes: Quantities in the charts are generally quoted in thousand tonnes of oil equivalent (ktoe).

10. Which of the following CANNOT be inferred from the charts?

- A) Compared with other sectors, the service sector consumed the least amount of energy during the last 40 years.
- B) Gas consumption was the main cause for the increase in energy consumption in the domestic sector from 2015 to 2016.
- C) From 1970 to 2016, energy consumption in the transport sector continued to grow mainly due to increasing consumption of petroleum.
- D) From 1970 to the mid-1980s, the industrial sector accounted for the largest share of energy consumption.

Chart 2 The change in energy consumption from 2015 to 2016 split by fuel and sector



Question 11 (Suggested completion time: 4 minutes)

Directions: *Read the text and answer the question according to the text.*

As a teenager, I would ask my parents to let me take the car so I could go to the local hangout (which, sadly, was McDonald’ s for teens in Oscoda, MI). They would want to know why I wanted to use the car, and I would patiently explain the situation. When told that I could not, in fact, borrow the car, the cry so often heard, “But Mom! Everyone’ s doing it!”

Therefore it must be the right thing to do... right?

Not necessarily. Moms across America will fire back, “If everyone jumped off a bridge, would you?”

Point taken.

11. Which of the following is NOT of the same logical fallacy as the underlined part in the text?

A) Driving home, you see a big traffic jam in front. You notice a few cars shooting over to the next lane. Would you follow them?

B) Feeling envy is only natural. Therefore, there’ s nothing wrong with feeling envy.

C) Bill: “I like classical music and I think it is of higher quality than most modern music.”

Jill: “That stuff is for old people.”

Dave: “Yeah, who would listen to that crap?”

Bill: “Well, I don’ t really like it that much.”

D) Everyone is selfish; everyone is doing what he believes will make himself happier. Why should you feel guilty for seeking your own happiness when that’ s what everyone else is doing, too?

Questions 12-13 (Suggested completion time: 6 minutes)

Directions: *Below is an excerpt from an article on Time Magazine’ s website which is linked to two logical fallacies. Read the excerpt and answer the questions according to the excerpt.*

Tech in the classroom not only leads to worse educational outcomes for kids, which I will explain shortly, it can also clinically hurt them. I’ ve worked with over a thousand teenagers in the past 15 years and have observed that students who have been raised on a high-tech diet not only appear to struggle more with attention and focus, but also seem to suffer from an adolescent malaise that appears to be a direct byproduct of their digital immersion. Indeed, over two hundred peer-reviewed studies point to screen time correlating to increased ADHD (Attention Deficit Hyperactivity Disorder), screen addiction, increased

aggression, depression, anxiety and even psychosis.

But let's look more closely at that claim. ADHD rates have indeed exploded by 50 percent over the past 10 years with the CDC (Centers for Disease Control) indicating that rates continue to rise by five percent per year.

Yet many researchers and neuroscientists believe that the ADHD epidemic is a direct result of children being hyper-stimulated. Using hyper-stimulating digital content to "engage" otherwise distracted students exacerbates the problem that it endeavors to solve. It creates a vicious and addictive ADHD cycle: The more a child is stimulated, the more that child needs to keep getting stimulated in order to hold their attention.

12. 12-13. Which TWO logical fallacies are employed in the text?

Paragraph 1:

Paragraph 2:

A. **False cause:** You presumed that a real or perceived relationship between things means that one is the cause of the other. Many people confuse correlation (things happening together or in sequence) for causation (that one thing actually causes the other to happen). Sometimes correlation is coincidental, or it may be attributable to a common cause.

B. **Straw man:** You misrepresented someone's argument to make it easier to attack. By exaggerating, misrepresenting, or just completely fabricating someone's argument, it's much easier to present your own position as being reasonable, but this kind of dishonesty serves to undermine honest rational debate.

C. **Anecdotal:** You used a personal experience or an isolated example instead of a sound argument or compelling evidence. It's often much easier for people to believe someone's testimony as opposed to understanding complex data and variation across a continuum. Quantitative scientific measures are almost always more accurate than personal perceptions and experiences, but our inclination is to believe that which is tangible to us, and/or the word of someone we trust over a more "abstract" statistical reality.

D. **Composition/division:** You assumed that one part of something has to be applied to all, or other, parts of it; or that the whole must apply to its parts. Often when something is true for the part it does also apply to the whole, or vice versa, but the crucial difference is whether there exists good evidence to show that this is the case. Because we observe consistencies in things, our thinking can become biased so that we presume consistency to exist where it does not.

Question 14 Challenge Your Brain (Suggested completion time: 4 minutes)

Directions: *Read the following text and answer the question according to the text.*

Albert and Bernard just became friends with Cheryl, and they want to know when her birthday is. Cheryl gives them a list of 10 possible dates.

May 15, 16, 19

June 17, 18

July 14, 16

August 14, 15, 17

Cheryl then tells Albert and Bernard separately the month and the day of her birthday respectively.

Albert: I don't know when Cheryl's birthday is, but I know that Bernard does not know too.

Bernard: At first I don't know when Cheryl's birthday is, but I know now.

Albert: Then I also know when Cheryl's birthday is.

14. So when is Cheryl's birthday?

Question 15 (Suggested completion time: 4 minutes)

Directions: Read the introduction to a scientific invention. Answer the question according to the introduction.

John von Neumann may have finally met his match. Nearly 70 years ago, the Hungarian-born polymath sketched out the basic design of modern computers, with separate processing, memory, and control units. But this year, computer engineers at IBM and other companies rolled out a promising alternative: the first large-scale "neuromorphic" chips, designed to process information in ways more akin to living brains.

Chips based on von Neumann's architecture excel at carrying out sequences of logical operations, such as those that underlie spreadsheets and word processors. But they struggle with tasks that integrate vast amounts of data, such as vision.

Our brains take a very different approach. Individual neurons communicate with thousands of their neighbors through chemical signals, enabling the brain to process lots of information in parallel. Different brain regions also specialize for greater efficiency.

The brain's network of 100 billion cells linked by 100 trillion synapses still dwarfs anything neuromorphic chips can muster. But IBM's new TrueNorth chip includes 5.4 billion transistors and 256 million "synapses," and the company is working to tile multiple TrueNorths together to build more complex networks. In the future, brain-like processors could transform fields such as machine vision and environmental monitoring, integrating real-time data from sensors from around the globe.

15. According to the text, which of the following is NOT one of the characteristics of the "neuromorphic" chips?

A) Distinctive visual faculty can be anticipated in these chips.

C) The chips can effectively accomplish logical operations.

B) The brain's network is the prototype for these chips.

D) Transistors, in a way, determine the ability of the chips' data-processing.

Question 16 (Suggested completion time: 4 minutes)

Directions: Read the text about chatbots. Answer the question according to the text.

Tech gurus at a top British university are working on automated bots which will gently nudge you into choosing a salad rather than a donut. These chatbots are designed to steer people in the right direction, sending messages to remind people to avoid fatty food. A chatbot is a computer program designed to talk with humans. They are already in use on Facebook Messenger, allowing users to do everything from ordering a pizza to checking the news by having a simulated “conversation” with the bots.

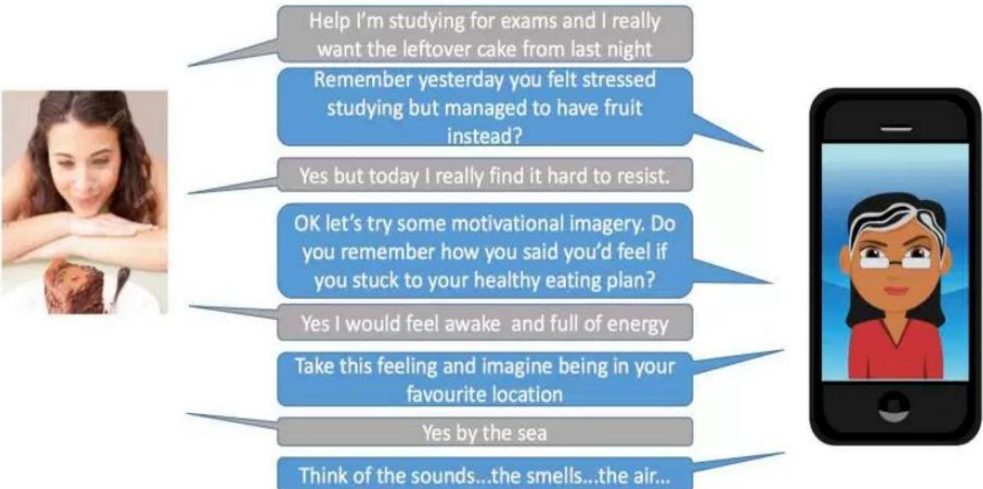
16. Which of the chats implies the following statement?

“Chatbots will work as a kind of ‘diary’ to collect the confessions of greedy people and record their diet choices.”

A)



C)



B)



Questions 17-18 (Suggested completion time: 6 minutes)

Directions: Read the text about dougong. Decide whether the statements are True, False or Not Given according to the text.

Architects have long turned to the past for inspiration. In this age of glass and steel, however, they're more likely to be looking for aesthetic influence than technical know-how.

But an ancient Chinese construction technique called *dougong* is a notable exception.

Consisting of a series of interlocking brackets, this building innovation may be more than 2,500 years old. From Beijing's Forbidden City to Sichuan Province's Baoyuan Temple, it has helped many of China's oldest buildings withstand earthquakes and natural disasters.

And now some of Asia's architects are looking to revive the ancient technique.

Built to last

Many structures built during the Tang and Song dynasties featured "curtain walls" which were, by definition, non-load-bearing. As a result, the unsupported wooden beams that shouldered the weight were prone to cracking and splitting.

Designers needed a technique which would more evenly distribute the burden across their structures. Their solution was *dougong*.

Translating as "cap (and) block," *dougong* is a system of wooden brackets that can support the overhanging roofs commonly found in Chinese architecture. The underlying physics are simple: The interlocking brackets transfer weight to vertical columns, lessening the strain on the horizontal beams. Nails or fasteners are not required.

This support system meant that even buildings made from latticework and mud could bear the weight of a heavy temple roof. It also meant that wooden frames became much more flexible while still maintaining their structural integrity—even in structures of substantial height.

As well as giving the illusion that buildings are "floating" in their frames, this flexibility offers protection against the forces of nature.

The famous Wooden Pagoda in Shanxi Province's Yingxian County is one of countless buildings believed to have benefited from this architectural innovation. Built in 1056, the pagoda straddles the Datong Basin's seismic belt. Yet it has withstood countless earthquakes, even when newer nearby buildings have collapsed.

Historian Klaus Zwerger traces the origins of *dougong* in his book *Wood and Wood Joints: Building Traditions of Europe, Japan, and China*.

"The Chinese building system is based on ratios and proportions," he wrote. "It draws on thousands of years of observations, on which dimensional proportions were structurally suitable and practical, coupled with a growing understanding of which proportions were aesthetically pleasing."



Over time, *dougong* has become as much about decoration as engineering, according to Nancy Steinhardt, professor of East Asian art at the University of Pennsylvania.

“Decorative rather than functional components first appear in the 13th to 14th centuries,” she said in an email interview. “As bracket sets became decorative, they also became smaller in comparison to the height of the pillars which interlock with them.”

“As one of the most recognizable symbols of Chinese architecture, the use of *dougong* always references not just Chinese architecture, but China (itself).”

17. *Dougong* has its unique aesthetic and technical value; therefore, it replaced “curtain walls” in ancient Chinese buildings.

A) True B) False C) Not Given

18. The Wooden Pagoda has survived many earthquakes thanks to the interlocking brackets transferring the natural force to vertical columns, lessening the strain on the horizontal beams.

A) True B) False C) Not Given

Questions 19-20 (Suggested completion time: 6 minutes)

Directions: Read the text about a movie. Answer the questions according to the text.



The success of *Wonder Woman* provided a golden ray of hope that Warner Bros. and DC had finally mastered this whole comic-book-movie thing. *Justice League*, by contrast, reflects the haste with which the parties rushed to create their cinematic universe and catch up with Marvel, leaping several intermediate steps in a single bound.

In one respect, this lavish superhero team-up is better than expected, yielding a few fun and clever moments, if one chooses to compare it to the bloated *Batman v. Superman: Dawn of Justice* and *Suicide Squad*.

On the other hand, it’s at best workmanlike, and nowhere near as polished and satisfying as *Wonder Woman*, which had the advantage of being a straightforward original story, stripped of conspicuous concerns about stringing together pieces to move action figures.

Warner Bros. made a choice years ago by essentially handing the keys to its superhero kingdom to director Zack Snyder, who put his stamp on *Man of Steel*, *Batman v. Superman* and now this.

Snyder is clearly a gifted visual stylist, someone who can bring what look like comic-book panels to three-dimensional life. It’s his characters that tend to be a little flat and somewhat humorless, a criticism that *Justice League* labors to address, with mixed results.

Although some of the groundwork was laid in *Batman v. Superman*, this latest movie still has to transact a great deal of business, setting up the _____ team members, uniting them under the grumpy stewardship of Batman and fending off an extraterrestrial threat.

19. Which of the following statements is indicated in the text?

- A) *Justice League* is less watchable than previous superhero movies by Warner Bros. C) *Wonder Woman* is a longtime decision by Warner Bros. to catch up with Marvel.
- B) Audiences are fascinated by the straightforward storyline in *Justice League*. D) Director Zack Snyder is both praised and criticized for his movie creations.

20. Which of the following words best fits in the blank in the last paragraph?

- A) divergent B) individual C) potential D) illusory

Questions 21-23 (Suggested completion time: 6 minutes)

Directions: Read the text and answer the questions according to the text.



As new parents and anyone who's ever gone rummaging through their old childhood libraries quickly realises, much of the best literature for kids is crazy. It all makes divine sense when you're four or five or 10, but return as an adult to *Alice's Adventures in Wonderland* or *The Cat in the Hat*, and what's striking is that so much sublime whimsy and exuberant creativity could have been conjured up by our fellow grownups.

Then again, there's a theory that children's authors—the best of them, at any rate—never really grow up. Lewis Carroll famously—notoriously from today's perspective—preferred playing games with children to adult conversation. Kenneth Grahame amassed a vast collection of toys—in his 20s. And Dodie Smith, a fascinating writer best known today for her

children's novel *The Hundred and One Dalmatians*, used to say she never felt quite grown up. (At under five feet tall and with a high-pitched, perpetually girlish voice, she perhaps had more excuses than most.)

There's no arguing that the behaviour of certain of these writers makes their whippersnapper protagonists look good as gold. Take night club entertainer and *Eloise* author, Kay Thompson. She was, by all accounts, a difficult woman to work with. Hilary Knight, *Eloise's* illustrator, finally threw in the towel after Thompson seized his hand in an attempt to direct his pencil. A fondness for flouncing off saw Thompson quit everything from a role in *The Pink Panther* (she hated her costume) to a gig concocting a fragrance for Tiffany's (she had "the mind of a grasshopper", one of the company's executives despaired).

The way publicists spun it, Eloise sprang spontaneously to life when, late for a rehearsal of her act with the Williams Brothers, the ordinarily punctual Thompson apologised in a child's voice. "Who are you, little girl?" someone asked, to which Thompson replied, "I am Eloise. I am 6." It became a rehearsal game, then a one-woman show at the Plaza in Manhattan, and finally, in 1955, a book. But according to biographer Sam Irvin, Eloise had been with Thompson since childhood, an imaginary friend whose voice she'd channeled all her life. When a made-for-TV film first started shooting, Thompson would hide under a table on set and voice Eloise's part herself, making the child actor cover her mouth with a book.

21. According to Paragraph 1, what attitude is described towards literature for kids?

- A) Ambivalent B) Conventional C) Sentimental D) Critical

22. 22-23. Match each description with the correct name given in the table.

Imitations of children can be observed in adult life.

Traces of childlike interests remain even in adult life.

A. Lewis Carroll

B. Kenneth Grahame

C. Dodie Smith

D. Kay Thompson

E. Hilary Knight

Questions 24-31 (Suggested completion time: 30 minutes)

Directions: Read three passages about "reading". Answer the questions according to the passages.

Passage A

The Chinese government has publicized a draft ordinance promoting "reading for all", to solicit public opinion, a move to create better reading habits among the population.

Realizing the importance of reading in national strength, China has gradually raised "reading for all" as a national strategy.

The call for a love of reading among all the population appeared in an array of important government and Communist Party of China (CPC) documents, including the report at the 18th CPC national congress and the government work reports delivered at the annual parliamentary session over the past four years.

There are still problems, however, which need to be resolved with the legislation, such as a lower reading rate compared with the world's major countries, inadequate and inequitable public resources, and mixed quality of reading materials.

A national survey by the Chinese Academy of Press and Publication showed that Chinese read 3.26 e-books and 4.58 paper books on average in 2015, compared with an average of 16 books in Europe and the United States.

Many major developed countries have already resorted to legislation to boost reading.

The United States introduced the Reading Excellence Act in 1998 and the No Child Left Behind Act in 2002. The Republic of Korea and Japan have also introduced laws to promote reading.

The draft ordinance, released by the Legislative Affairs Office of China's State Council, states that governments at or above county level should incorporate reading programs into their economic and social development plan, as well as their annual budget.

It encourages schools and academies to open their libraries to the public, and calls on brick-and-mortar bookstores to reserve reading space and organized reading for customers.

In addition, poor, remote and border regions, as well as those inhabited mainly by ethnic minority groups are expected to get special support under the draft.

With more funds, more libraries are now available, and the law should breathe life into the nation's reading habits.

Passage B

Better pay attention, reader. This whole story may be a blur.

For the first time, researchers have demonstrated the ill effects of mindless reading—a phenomenon in which people take in sentence after sentence without really paying attention.

Ever read the same paragraph three times? Or get to the end of a page and realize you don't know what you just read?

That's mindless reading. It is the literary equivalent of driving to a destination without remembering how you got there—something so common many people don't even notice it.

In a new study of college students, researchers from the University of Pittsburgh and the University of British Columbia established a way to study mindless reading in a lab.

Their findings showed that daydreaming has its costs.

The readers who zoned out most tended to do the worst on tests of reading comprehension—a significant, if not surprising, result.

The study also suggested that zoning out caused the poor test results, as opposed to other possible factors, such as the complexity of the text or the task.

The researchers hope their work inspires more research into why zoning out happens, and what can be done to stop it.

For now, they want the problem to be taken seriously.

"When you talk about this work at conferences, it does lend itself to a lot of jokes," acknowledges University of Pittsburgh professor Erik Reichle, co-leader of the study.

"It's so *ubiquitous*. Everybody does it," he said. "I think that's one of the main reasons it's been overlooked. And there's been a view that it is tough to study experimentally. Hopefully, now, there will be more interest in the topic."

The federal government is showing some.

Reichle and fellow psychology professor Jonathan Schooler did the study on a \$691,000 grant from the Institute of Education Sciences, an arm of the Education Department. It is one of 178 federally backed projects aimed at giving schools a scientific basis for sound policies.

Over three experiments, students used computers to read the first five chapters of Leo Tolstoy's *War and Peace*. (Reichle wanted some boring reading—better for zoning out.)

Reichle said the dry text itself did not skew the results toward mindless wandering. After all, the students were on alert, unlike the typical reader.

Participants were told to monitor and report instances of zoning out as they read text on a computer. Half of them got computer reminders, too: “Were you zoning out?”

Despite all that, many still reported zoning out at a regular pace.

“That’s the amazing thing,” Reichle said. “It shows how often this can happen even under conditions that are designed to keep it from happening.”

The students said as their eyes scanned the words, their minds often were elsewhere.

They were hungry, or thirsty, or tired. They were thinking about plans, worries or memories. Some drifted into fantasies. Others stuck with the book, but their minds wandered into tangents about the plot.

Passage C

Illiteracy in the modern world is like trying to navigate the high seas with neither knowledge of the stars, a map or a compass—possible, but needlessly difficult. But new research suggests that learning to read does more than make life easier: it literally changes how the brain works by increasing connectivity between its regions.

“We’re trying to understand the basic principle of how the brain works,” says Falk Huettig, a researcher in the department of psychology of language at the Max Planck Institute for Psycholinguistics. “One good way to figure out how the brain works is to look at cultural inventions, things like reading that is fairly recent in the history of humans.”

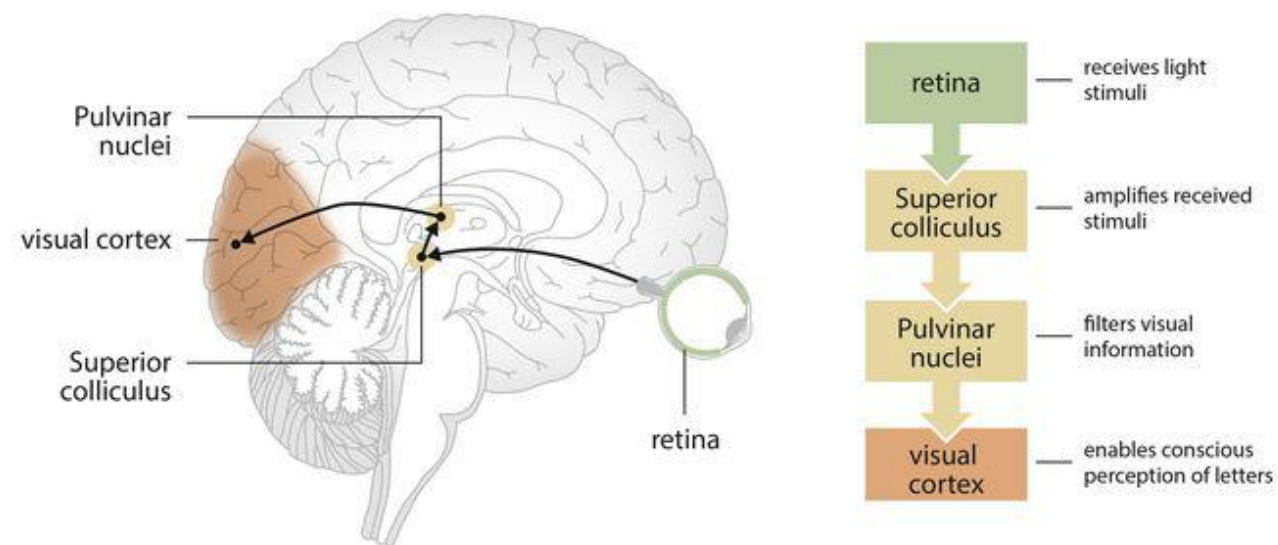
Huettig also notes that if we understand how reading is acquired and how the brain changes as we learn, we can also figure out what brain differences might cause conditions such as dyslexia, for example.

Reading is especially interesting because it’s complex. It requires pattern recognition, and decoding symbols to create a meaning. Take, for example, the word “blue”. To read it, you have to recognize each letter, what they mean when placed in this order, and relate that coded message to the color that exists in the real world—in milliseconds.

To understand how reading affects the brain, Huettig and a team of researchers took two groups of illiterate Hindi-speaking Indian adults in their thirties and matched them for gender, handedness (right handed vs. left), income, number of literate family members, and intelligence. Adults were used instead of children because kids’ brains are incredibly flexible—it’s why they learn languages so much more easily than adults can—and they’re constantly learning new things, which makes it harder to pinpoint which brain changes might relate to each new skill.

Both groups had their brains scanned in an fMRI machine, to get a base level understanding of how their brains worked. Afterwards, one group undertook six months of literacy instruction in the Devanagari script, a

View into the right hemisphere



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writing system used for several languages including Hindi. The other group received no such instruction. After six months, the researches scanned their subjects again. As we learn to read, neuroplasticity conquers a network that is deeply rooted in the brain. This reorganization makes us increasingly efficient at visually navigating through letter strings, or a group of letters that appear in a word (for example, the “str” in string, straight, and strike).

By tracking blood flow to different regions of the brain, the researchers discovered that the group who had received literacy changes exhibited noticeable differences in their brains. Parts of the cerebral cortex, the outer layer of the cerebrum that plays a role in memory, attention, thought and, yes, language, changed, though that was not wholly

surprising. Previous studies had shown that parts of the cortex change when we learn to read.

What was surprising, however, was that there was also increased functional connectivity between deeper regions of the brain including the occipital lobe (which plays a role in visual processing).

“It hasn’t been shown before that even these very deep structures in the brain that are evolutionarily old still change fundamentally, and adapt to this new skill, and start to communicate effectively with parts of the cortex like the visual cortex,” says Huettig.

Huettig’s study also suggests that some previous research on dyslexia might be wrong. Some studies pointed to abnormalities in the deep structures of the brains of people with dyslexia as a cause of the reading disorder. But in Huettig’s research, the first round of brain scans showed some of those abnormalities—that is, the illiterate adults had brains that looked a lot like those of dyslexics—but in the group that learned to read, those abnormalities went away.

“What our study suggests is that these changes in the deep structures of the brain have much more to do with learning to read,” says Huettig. “These differences between people who can read well and people who cannot read well are not the cause of dyslexia.”

24. According to Passage A, why has the Chinese government legislated a reading campaign?

- A) Because a better reading habit can be created this way.
- B) Because the government wants people to read more.
- C) Because most developed countries did so.
- D) Because reading has become a national strategy.

25. Which of the following measures is NOT included in the draft ordinance in Passage A?

- A) To build more public libraries and bookstores.
- B) To have the reading program as part of the governmental works.
- C) To provide fiscal support to the reading programs.
- D) To give special support to some special regions.

26. What question has the study in Passage B attempted to answer?

- A) Who are most likely to zone out while reading?
- B) How can we prevent ourselves from daydreaming?
- C) What are the possible results of mindless reading?
- D) What causes mindless reading?

27. The word **ubiquitous** in Passage B is closest in meaning to ____.

- A) common
- B) interesting
- C) unique
- D) amazing

28. The purpose of the research on reading by Falk Huettig in Passage C is ____.

- A) to comprehend the mechanism of the brain.
- B) to figure out the cause of cerebral illness.
- C) to illustrate the changes of brain caused by reading.
- D) to find out the impact of cultural inventions on the brain.

29. Which is the best title for Passage C?

- A) Learning to Read as an Adult Might Change the Way Your Brain Works
- B) How Does the Brain Work When Reading
- C) New Findings on the Causes of Dyslexia
- D) Literacy or Illiteracy Has a Lot to Do with the Deep Regions of One's Brain

30. Who has been involved in both Passage A and Passage B?

- A) Governments
- B) Education departments
- C) Schools
- D) Legislative departments

31. What can be learned about the experiments in Passage B and Passage C?

- A) Both aimed at providing a scientific basis for policy making.
- B) Both reported some unexpected findings.
- C) Both were supported by the government.
- D) Both had young men as subjects.

Question 32 (Suggested completion time: 40 minutes)

Directions: Read the passage about overconfidence from *Thinking, Fast and Slow* by Daniel Kahneman, winner of the Nobel Prize. Write a short essay according to the passage.

Can overconfident optimism be overcome by training? I am not optimistic. There have been numerous attempts to train people to state confidence intervals that reflect the imprecision of their judgments, with only a

few reports of modest success. An often cited example is that geologists at Royal Dutch Shell became less overconfident in their assessments of possible drilling sites after training with multiple past cases for which the outcome was known. In other situations, overconfidence was mitigated when judges were encouraged to consider competing hypotheses. However, overconfidence is a direct consequence of features of System 1 (Referring to the human mind, System 1 operates automatically and quickly, with little or no effort and no sense of voluntary control) that can be tamed—but not vanquished. The main obstacle is that subjective confidence is determined by the coherence of the story one has constructed, not by the quality and amount of the information that supports it.

Organizations may be better able to tame optimism and individuals than individuals are. The best idea for doing so was contributed by Gary Klein, my “adversarial collaborator” who generally defends intuitive decision making against claims of bias and is typically hostile to algorithms. He labels his proposal the *premortem*. The procedure is simple: when the organization has almost come to an important decision but has not formally committed itself, Klein proposes gathering for a brief session a group of individuals who are knowledgeable about the decision. The premise of the session is a short speech: “Imagine that we are a year into the future. We implemented the plan as it now exists. The outcome was a disaster. Please take 5 to 10 minutes to write a brief history of that disaster.”

Gary Klein’s idea of the *premortem* usually evokes immediate enthusiasm. After I described it casually at a session in Davos, someone (the CEO of a major international corporation) behind me muttered, “It was worth coming to Davos just for this!” The *premortem* has two main advantages: it overcomes the groupthink that affects many teams once a decision appears to have been made, and it unleashes the imagination of knowledgeable individuals in a much-needed direction.

As a team converges on a decision—and especially when the leader tips her hand—public doubts about the wisdom of the planned move are gradually suppressed and eventually come to be treated as evidence of flawed loyalty to the team and its leaders. The suppression of doubt contributes to overconfidence in a group where only supporters of the decision have a voice. The main virtue of the *premortem* is that it legitimizes doubts. Furthermore, it encourages even supporters of the decision to search for possible threats that they had not considered earlier. The *premortem* is not a panacea and does not provide complete protection against nasty surprises, but it goes some way toward reducing the damage of plans that are subject to the biases of WYSIATI (What you see is all there is) and uncritical optimism.

32. Write a short essay of about 300 words based on your understanding of the passage. Remember to write in your OWN words. Your essay should respond to the following questions:

- 1) With regard to judgment, what is the author’s general attitude towards overconfident optimism?
- 2) In what situations did the author find from numerous attempts that overconfidence was mitigated?
- 3) In what way can the proposal of the *premortem* help minimize the bad consequences of optimism?
- 4) Do you think overconfidence is a bad thing? Please explain.